

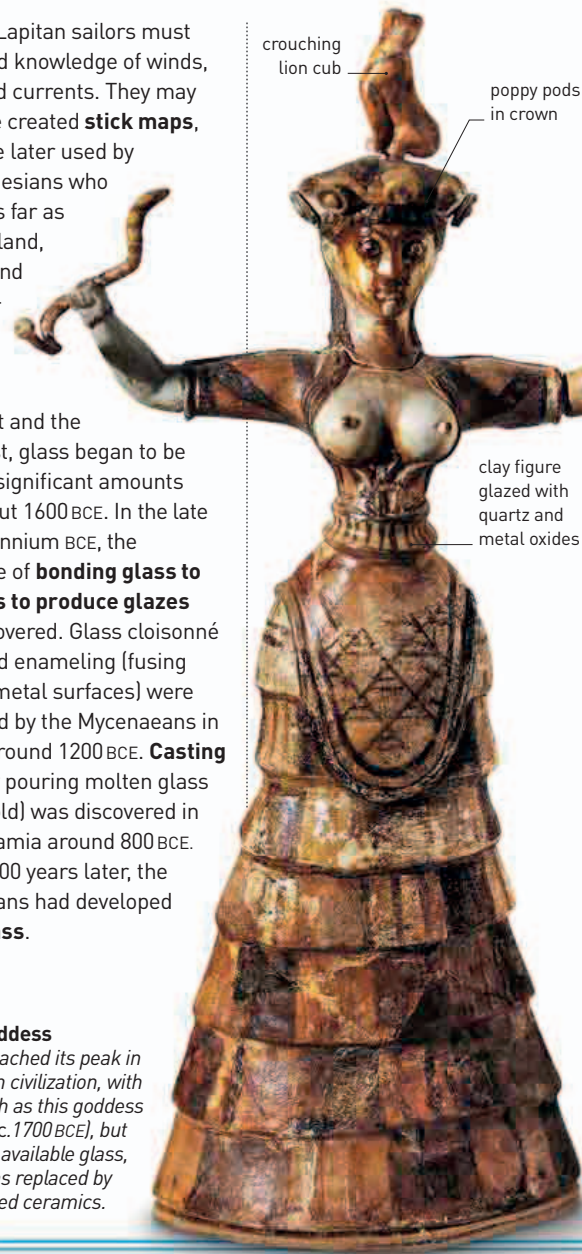


An Assyrian bronze relief of the mid-9th century BCE shows war chariots carrying soldiers to assault the city of Khazazu (present-day Azaz, in Syria).

this, the Lapitan sailors must have used knowledge of winds, stars, and currents. They may also have created **stick maps**, like those later used by the Polynesians who settled as far as Easter Island, Hawaii, and (by 1000–1200 CE) New Zealand.

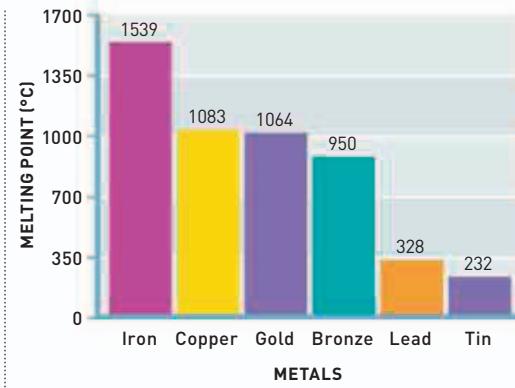
In Egypt and the Near East, glass began to be made in significant amounts from about 1600 BCE. In the late 2nd millennium BCE, the technique of **bonding glass to ceramics to produce glazes** was discovered. Glass cloisonné inlays and enameling (fusing glass to metal surfaces) were developed by the Mycenaeans in Greece around 1200 BCE. **Casting glass** (by pouring molten glass into a mold) was discovered in Mesopotamia around 800 BCE. Around 100 years later, the Phoenicians had developed **clear glass**.

Snake goddess
Faience reached its peak in the Minoan civilization, with works such as this goddess statuette (c. 1700 BCE), but with more available glass, faience was replaced by glass-glazed ceramics.



crouching lion cub
poppy pods in crown
clay figure glazed with quartz and metal oxides

The invention of the spoked wooden wheel around 2000 BCE, along with the **domestication of the horse**, opened up new possibilities in land transport, permitting lighter vehicles and eventually the use of adaptable riding animals. Although harnesses were in use from the 3rd millennium BCE, significant advances began to be made from c. 1500 BCE. The **halter yoke**, with flat straps across the neck and chest of the animal, made horses more efficient at **pulling light chariots**. Weighing as little as 66 lb (30 kg), these chariots could carry two warriors and became crucial to many Near Eastern armies. The **preservation of corpses** had its origins in the natural process of drying out and



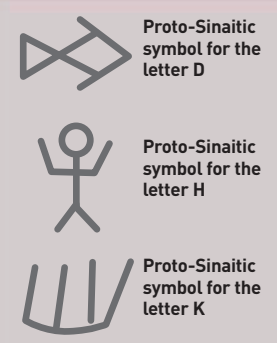
Melting point of metals
Iron melts at a far higher temperature than other metals used in early metallurgy. China was first to master the technology to melt iron.

preserving bodies in the desert sand. These corpses were wrapped in linen bandages dipped in resin, which also helped to prevent the bodies from decaying. By around 2700 BCE, the Egyptians had discovered that natron (a mixture of salts) **desiccated flesh and could be used to mummify bodies**. They gradually refined this process until it reached a peak of

sophistication around 1000 BCE. Bodies were mummified by removing the internal organs (apart from the heart), washing out the body cavity, and packing it with natron for 40 days to dry it out. The natron was removed and replaced with clean packets of natron and linen soaked in resin to restore the body's shape before being coated in resin and bandaged in linen.

EARLY SCRIPTS

The transition from symbolic scripts to an alphabetic one, where each individual sign represents a sound in the language, seems to have first taken place among miners in the Sinai desert of Egypt around 1800 BCE. The signs appear to derive from Egyptian hieratic script (a cursive script that developed alongside the hieroglyphic system), but there are few inscriptions in this proto-Sinaitic alphabet and it is not certain whether slightly later alphabets in the region, such as proto-Canaanite (17th century BCE) and Ugaritic (13th century BCE), derived from it or developed separately. By 1050 BCE, proto-Canaanite had evolved into the Phoenician script that is the ancestor of Greek and other European scripts.



Proto-Sinaitic symbol for the letter D
Proto-Sinaitic symbol for the letter H
Proto-Sinaitic symbol for the letter K

